

Student Services Board Report
March 30, 2026
Alyson Finley

**Special
Education**

Transition Planning for 2026-2027 Our Special Education team continues to collaborate to support transitions for students moving to new buildings for the upcoming 2026-2027 school year. Teachers are proactively collaborating to share student-specific data and strategies, ensuring a **seamless and supportive** transition.

Alignment to Core Values:

Collaborative: Teachers work across buildings to ensure continuity of care.

Inclusive: We prioritize environments where every student is prepared for success in their next academic setting.

Extended School Year (ESY) Services Special Education teams continue to determine eligibility for Extended School Year Services. These services are designed for students who demonstrate significant regression over summer breaks with a recoupment period beyond typical expectations, ensuring their educational progress remains on track. Most ESY decisions will be made by March 30, 2026.

Alignment to Core Values:

Supportive: We provide targeted interventions to meet the unique needs of our learners.

Passionate: Our staff is dedicated to ensuring student growth does not stall during instructional gaps.

Special Education Rosters and Staffing Special Education teachers have been creating and updating rosters for the 2026-2027 school year to ensure appropriate staffing, support, and resources will be available to students.

Alignment to Core Values:

Supportive: We are ensuring that every student has the academic and emotional support they need by proactively planning for appropriate staffing levels and specialized supports.

Collaborative: Teachers and administrators are working together to build a culture of teamwork, sharing data to ensure a seamless transition and

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consistent support for all students across the district.

Inclusive: This planning process ensures we are creating a community where every student, regardless of their needs, is valued and has the necessary resources to feel empowered in their learning environment.

ELL

Lau Plan Development The Lau Plan team convened for its third meeting on March 23, 2026 to continue drafting the new district-wide Lau Plan. The team's deep knowledge of ELL processes and procedures ensures a robust framework will be in place for the 2026-2027 school year. The team will be ready to roll this out for review by the end of the 25-26 school year. School Board Members, we would love a volunteer to have someone on the review committee! Please email alyson.finley@dcgschools.com if you are interested in being on the review committee.

Alignment to Core Values:

Collaborative: This project relies on a partnership of experts working together to define our district's long-term ELL strategy.

Inclusive: The Lau Plan is a foundational document that ensures we meet the diverse linguistic needs of all students, guaranteeing them equitable access to their education.

ELPA-21 Summative Assessment Our ELL teachers have completed all ELPA-21 summative assessments. The resulting data is critical for determining student readiness to exit ELL services and for tailoring future instructional decisions to meet individual student needs.

Alignment to Core Values:

Innovative: We use specific, data-driven assessment results to refine our instructional delivery and modernize how we support language learners.

Passionate: Our teachers are dedicated to accurately measuring student growth to ensure every learner reaches their full potential.

EL Strategies for All Classroom Teachers The ELL teachers have been collaborating with Cindra Porter from AEA and instructional coaches in each building to develop professional learning that will be provided to all teachers on April 1, 2026.

Alignment to DCG Core Values:

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Collaborative: This initiative is a prime example of teamwork across different levels of expertise. By partnering with external experts (AEA) and internal leaders (instructional coaches), the ELL teachers are breaking down silos to ensure professional learning is cohesive and high-quality.

Inclusive: Providing EL strategies to *all* classroom teachers reinforces the value that every student belongs in every classroom. It ensures that students with diverse linguistic backgrounds have equitable access to the curriculum and are fully integrated into the school community.

Passionate: This commitment to training every teacher demonstrates a deep dedication to student growth, ensuring that no matter which classroom a learner enters, they are met with an educator equipped to support them.

Counseling

Curriculum and Program Review The K-6 counseling team is currently engaged in a comprehensive review of curriculum materials. In partnership with Sue Schirmer, counselors are also continuing their formal program review to standardize and align counseling services across the district. This ensures that every student, regardless of their building, has access to a high-quality, Tier 1 counseling program.

Alignment to Core Values:

Collaborative: Counselors are working together across all elementary buildings and with external expertise to ensure a cohesive and unified approach to student support.

Inclusive: By aligning the program district-wide, we guarantee that all students have equitable access to the same high-quality resources and social-emotional support.

Supportive: The curriculum review process is focused on identifying the most effective tools to meet the diverse developmental and emotional needs of our K-6 students.

Innovative: This review allows us to modernize our guidance practices, ensuring our curriculum reflects current best practices in school counseling and student mental health.

Passionate: Our counseling team remains dedicated to continuous improvement, seeking out the best possible materials to foster a positive and safe learning environment for every child.

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**Special
Education
&
Networking
Systems**

I continue to attend monthly engagements with the Metro Area Directors of Special Education. This collaborative network ensures the district remains at the forefront of local and statewide developments, providing an opportunity for sharing innovative ideas and engaging in collective problem-solving.

Alignment to Core Values:

Collaborative: By maintaining active partnerships with educational leaders across Iowa, we foster a culture of shared expertise that strengthens our internal programs and problem-solving capabilities.

Innovative: Networking allows us to stay apprised of emerging trends and statewide developments, ensuring DCG adopts forward-thinking strategies and modern best practices in student services.

Supportive: Engaging with colleagues in similar roles provides a system of professional support that helps us navigate complex educational challenges and find the best solutions for our staff and students.

Passionate: Our commitment to continuous learning through these sessions demonstrates our dedication to providing the highest quality of service and leadership for the DCG community.